LECTURE 2

HISTORICAL METHODS, SOURCES AND PRACTICES

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Learning Objectives

- **The lecture covers two complementary perspectives**

Lange explains **how historians explain historical change**, while Backerra explains **how historians evaluate and interpret evidence.**

Together they answer two fundamental questions:

- How do historians explain the past?
- How do historians know whether evidence is trustworthy?

- **Objectives of this study:**
  - Explain what historical methods are.
  - Distinguish between historical sources and historical evidence.
  - Understand comparative-historical methods.
  - Apply principles of source criticism.
  - Appreciate how cultural history has expanded historical research.

What Are Historical Methods?

- **Historical methods are systematic ways of investigating the past.** Historical research is analytical—not merely descriptive.

- They include:
  - Asking research questions
  - Finding evidence
  - Evaluating sources
  - Comparing societies
  - Explaining change
  - Presenting historical arguments

Thus, historians explain **why** events happened. This connects with Lange's argument that historical methods seek causal explanations rather than simple narratives.

Four Stages of the Historical Method

Stage	Purpose	Key Question	Failure Mode
Heuristics	Collection of evidence	"What survives, where is it?"	Missing extant evidence or mistaking derivative copies
Criticism	Evaluation of authenticity and reliability	"Is it genuine? Is its author credible?"	Mis-attribution, fraud, naively accepting biased testimony
Hermeneutics	Interpretation of meaning	"What did the author mean, in context?"	Anachronism, projection of modern categories
Synthesis	Reconstruction and narrative	"How do the parts fit into a coherent account?"	Whig narrative teleology, decontextualized pastiche

Source Taxonomy and Selection

Type	Definition	Examples in History	Contrast
Primary	Created during the time under study	Diaries, letters, court proceedings, legislative debates, newspapers, photographs	Contemporaneous, uninterpreted
Secondary	Analyses, assesses, or interprets a historical event	Scholarly journal articles, monographs, biographies	Synthesising, retrospective
Tertiary	Synthesises and summarises primary and secondary	Encyclopaedias, textbooks, bibliographies	Reference, distanced

Backerra argues that almost anything surviving from the past can become a historical source if it helps answer a research question.

Schools of Historiography: Five Contending Approaches

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=GSoc5MX0s8A

School	Periodisation	Focal Evidence	Key Method	Canonical Critique
German Historicist (Ranke)	Event-driven	Archival primary sources	Source-critical reading of state papers	E.H. Carr: "naive objectivism"
Annales (Bloch, Febvre, Braudel)	*Longue duree*	Geography, demographics, agronomy	Multidisciplinary, regressive method (moving chronologically backwards from the present)	Apolitical, "reluctance to study contemporary history"
Marxist (Marx, Friedrich Engels, Thompson)	Epochal (modes of production)	Class conflict, labour archives	Historical materialism	Deterministic, teleological
Subaltern / Postcolonial (Guha, Spivak)	Anti-imperial	Peasants, subaltern testimony	Recovery of marginalized voices	Risk of essentialism
Cliometrics / Digital (Fogel, North)	Quantitative periods	Statistical series, big data	Econometrics, data mining	Reduction of meaning to numbers

Practice: Oral History and Archival Research

Practice	Authoritative Body	Stages	Ethical Anchor
Oral History	Oral History Association (OHA)	Preparation; interviewing; preservation; access	Informed consent on record
Archival Research	American Historical Association (AHA)	Pre-trip planning; on-site navigation; post-trip citation	Provenance + chain of custody

Synthesis: Convergent Implications

Dimension	Shared Commitment	Divergence
Evidence	Read primary sources where possible	Ranke: archives are paramount; Thucydides: eyewitness; Cliometrics: statistics
Distance	Avoid anachronism	Butterfield: contingent past over progressive present; Subaltern: actors as colleagues; Annales: mentalite rather than event
Disclosure	Acknowledge bias	Carr: disclose selection; White: disclose emplotment; Thompson: disclose framing of class

Tensions cut across the field:

Objectivity vs. disclosure. Ranke treated the historian as a transparent recorder; White argued transparency is itself rhetorical - establishing what the historian should disclose. Modern practice opts for explicit disclosure: state the question, the source set, and the framing.

Event vs. structure. Annales elevated structure; rank-and-file narrativist elevated event. Digital and cliometric methods can recover both, but only by separating the data (events, measurements) from the model (structure). Without that separation, quantification becomes Whiggish teleology.

Recovery vs. representation. Subaltern studies' instinct (recover excluded voices) and postmodern scepticism (any representation is partial) together produce strong ethical requirements: return narratives to participants, record consent, allow restricted access.

Comparative-Historical Methods (Lange)

- **Main Characteristics**
  - Compare multiple societies
  - Study long-term historical change
  - Explain causes
  - Combine historical narratives with social theory
  - Identify similarities and differences

- **Examples**
  - Revolutions
  - Democracy
  - Colonialism
  - Capitalism
  - State formation

Identify causal mechanisms rather than simple chronological events.

Source Criticism (Backerra)

- **Four Stages**
  - Heuristic
  - Source Analysis
  - Interpretation
  - Presentation

- **Questions Historians ask**
  - Who wrote it?
  - Why?
  - For whom?
  - Can it be trusted?
  - What does it reveal?

Good history depends on questioning sources before accepting their claims.
This is the foundation of all historical research.

Cultural History Expands Historical Sources

- **Traditional History focused on**
  - Government archives
  - Official documents
  - Political correspondence

- **Cultural History also studies**
  - Rituals
  - Symbols
  - Emotions
  - Material culture
  - Literature
  - Newspapers
  - Personal letters
  - Everyday life

Backerra argues that historians now ask different questions.
Instead of asking: "What happened?"
They also ask: "What did this event mean?"
Example: A diplomatic letter reveals political negotiations but also social hierarchy through handwriting, language, and layout.

Comparing Lange and Backerra

Lange	Backerra
Explains historical change	Explains how evidence is evaluated
Focuses on causation	Focuses on source criticism
Uses comparison	Uses interpretation
Builds theories	Builds reliable evidence

The relationship:

Backerra asks: "Can we trust this evidence?"

Lange asks: "What does this evidence explain?"
One provides reliable data.
The other provides explanation.

Lange shows **how historians explain the past** through comparison, causation, and long-term analysis.
Backerra shows **how historians evaluate and interpret sources** before those explanations can be made.
Together, they illustrate the complete workflow of historical scholarship:

ask questions → gather sources → critically evaluate evidence → compare cases → interpret findings → construct evidence-based historical explanations.

This integrated perspective provides a strong foundation in historical methods, sources, and practices.

Key Takeaways

- Historical research requires
  - ✓ Reliable evidence
  - ✓ Critical source analysis
  - ✓ Comparison
  - ✓ Context
  - ✓ Interpretation
  - ✓ Causal explanation

- History is both an art of interpretation and a science of evidence.

- Knowing historiography

https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=jtsjuZHOEb4

- New methods of learning History

https://www.edutopia.org/article/7-digital-tools-that-help-bring-history-to-life?utm_content=linkpos2&utm_campaign=weekly-2024-02-28&utm_medium=email&utm_source=edu-newsletter